Chapter 1
Third move sidelines

In the first chapter we will take a look at all the more or less sensible moves apart from 3…♗c5 and 3…♘f6.
Three of them – 3…f5?!, 3…♘d4?! and 3…h6?! – are dubious because Black neglects his development. White gets an advantage with natural moves. After 3…d6 and 3…♗e7 White can transpose to Chapter 3, but we also offer an independent possibility which promises White an advantage. 3…g6 is an interesting attempt to avoid highly theoretical paths. Black's plan is a little slow, so White has to play energetically in the centre. With the offer of a nice pawn sacrifice he grabs the initiative and enjoys a better position after the opening.

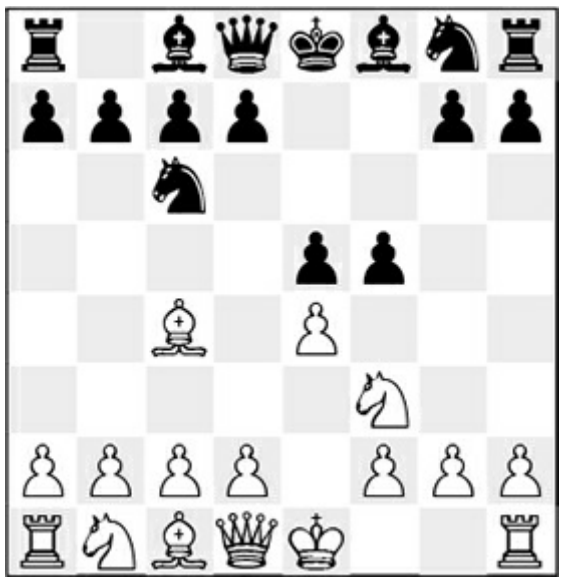
1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♗c4

The following moves are played mostly at amateur level.

3…g6

This attempt can be considered seriously. Black wants to develop his bishop to g7 and his knight on g8 to e7.

A) **3…f5?!**



analysis diagram

This hyper-aggressive move weakens the kingside and contradicts the general rules in the opening. White gets a big advantage with either 4.d4 or 4.d3.

A1) **4.d4** and now:

A11) **4…fxe4 5.♘xe5 d5 6.♗b5 ♕d6 7.c4! a6 8.♗xc6+** 8.♗a4 b5 9.cxb5 ♘xe5 10.dxe5 ♕xe5 11.b6+ ♗d7 12.♗xd7+ ♔xd7 13.♗e3 ♗b4+ 14.♘c3 ♗xc3+ 15.bxc3 cxb6 16.♗d4± Wosch-Daenen, LSS email 2007. **8…bxc6 9.0-0 ♘f6 10.♘c3 ♗e7 11.♗f4 ♕e6 12.f3±** Stanitz-Daenen, ICCF email 2009;

A12) **4…exd4 5.e5!**

analysis diagram

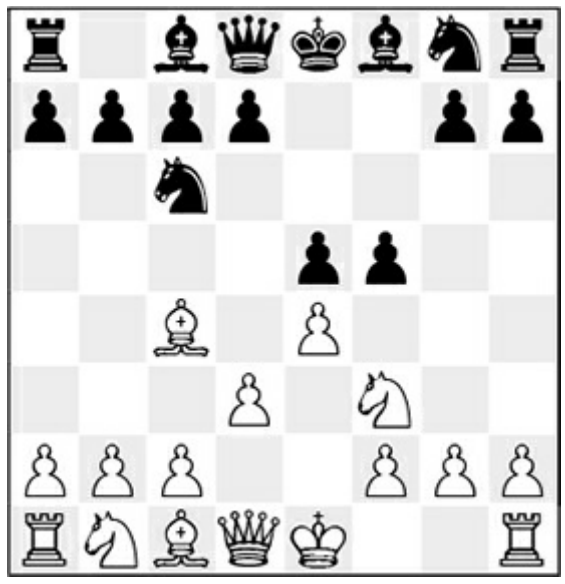
This move is very convincing, as the following examples show. The black king comes under fire. **5…d6** The subsequent moves are more or less forced, and the result of the following correspondence game puts an end to this variation. 5…♗b4+?! 6.c3! dxc3 7.bxc3 ♗f8? (7…d5 8.♗xd5 ♗c5 9.♗a3 ♗xa3 10.♘xa3 ♘ge7 11.c4±) 8.♗g5 ♘ge7 9.♕b3 d5 10.exd6 ♕xd6 11.♗f7+ ♔d8 12.0-0+– Burk-Holwell, corr 1990. **6.exd6 ♕xd6** 6…♗xd6 7.0-0 ♘f6 8.♖e1+ ♔f8 9.c3±. **7.0-0 ♗e7 8.♖e1 ♗d7 9.♘g5 ♘h6 10.♘e6! ♗xe6 11.♖xe6 ♕c5 12.b3! 0-0-0 13.♗a3**

analysis diagram

13…♘b4 14.♕e1! ♘xc2 15.♗xc5 ♘xe1 16.♖xe7 ♘c2 17.♘a3 ♘xa1 18.♘b5! b6 18…d3? 19.♗xa7!+–; 18…♖he8 19.♗e6+ ♔b8 20.♗xa7+ ♔a8 21.♖xe8 ♖xe8 22.♘xc7+ ♔xa7 23.♘xe8 d3 24.♔f1 g6 25.♗c4±. **19.♗b4 d3 20.♗d2 g5?!** 20…♖he8 21.♖xc7+ ♔b8 22.♖xg7 ♘g4 23.♘c7 ♖e2 24.♘a6+ ♔a8 25.♖g8! ♔b7 26.♖xd8 ♖xd2 27.♖d7+ ♔c8 28.♖xd3±. **21.♘xc7+–** Voracek-Vegjeleki, ICCF email 2007)

A13) **4…d6 5.♘g5 ♘h6** (Gardner-Jung, Brantford 1999) **6.d5!N ♘e7 7.♘c3±**

A2) **4.d3**



analysis diagram

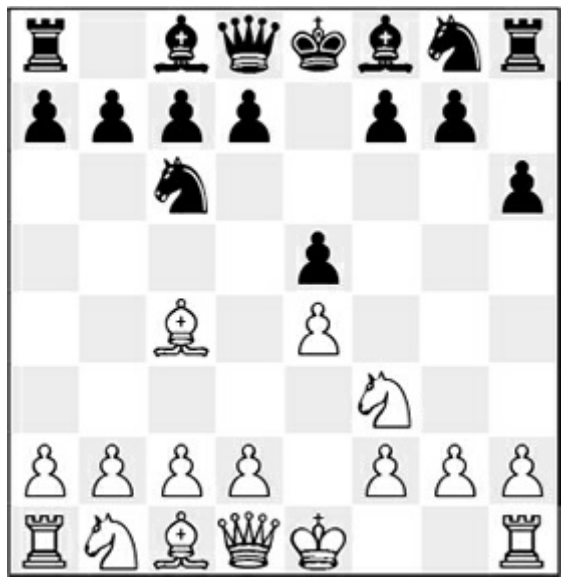
4...♘f6 4...d6 5.0-0 ♗e7 (5...f4 (Milosevic-Costa, Switzerland tt 1993) 6.d4!N ♗g4 7.♗b5 ♘ge7 8.d5 a6 9.♗e2±) 6.♘c3 ♗f6 (Reeh-Bach, Hamburg 2000) 7.b4!?N fxe4 (7...♘xb4 8.♖b1 ♘c6 9.exf5 ♗xf5 10.d4 ♘ge7 11.dxe5 dxe5 12.♕e2±) 8.dxe4 ♘xb4 9.♖b1 ♘c6 10.h3±. **5.0-0 ♗c5 6.♘c3 d6** 6...f4 7.♘d5 d6 8.c3 ♗g4 9.b4 ♗b6 10.a4 a5 11.♘xb6 cxb6 (Bojkov-Dimitrov, Sunny Beach 2012) 12.b5 ♘e7 13.h3 ♗h5 14.♗e6 ♘g6 15.g4! fxg3 16.fxg3±. **7.♗g5! ♘a5** 7...h6? 8.♗xf6 gxf6 9.exf5 h5 10.♘h4 ♘d4 11.♘e4 ♘xf5 12.♘xf5 ♗xf5 13.♘xc5 dxc5 14.♕f3±. **8.♗xf6 ♕xf6 9.♘d5 ♕d8 10.b4 ♘xc4 11.bxc5 fxe4 12.dxc4 exf3 13.♕xf3 c6 14.♘c3 ♕f6 15.♘e4 ♕xf3 16.♘xd6+ ♔e7 17.gxf3±** Fryer-Lyell, Hastings 2003.

B) **3...♘d4?!**

analysis diagram

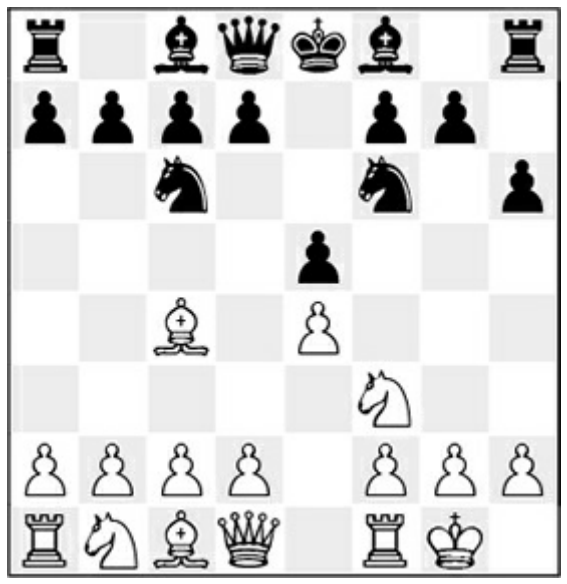
4.♘xd4 4.♘xe5?! ♕g5! is a very well known old trap. Although the position after 5.♗xf7+ ♔d8 6.0-0! ♕xe5 7.c3 ♘e6 8.d3 is far from clear, it makes sense for White to react in a more natural and conservative manner. **4...exd4 5.0-0 ♘f6 6.♖e1 d6 7.c3±** White has a lead in development and takes control over the centre.

C) **3...h6?!**



analysis diagram

This is played quite a lot at amateur level. Black worries about the knight jumping to g5. Obviously the move loses precious time. **4.0-0 ♘f6** 4…♗c5 5.c3 (of course. White builds up a strong centre) 5…d6 6.d4 exd4 (6…♗b6 7.dxe5 dxe5 8.♕xd8+ ♘xd8 9.♘xe5±) 7.cxd4 ♗b6 8.♘c3 (8.♕b3?! (Antonio-Ahmed, Ha Long City 2009) 8…♘a5! 9.♕a4+ ♗d7 10.♗b5 ♘f6∞) 8…♘ge7 (8…♘f6 9.h3 0-0 10.♖e1±; 8…♗g4 9.♗b5±) 9.h3±.



analysis diagram

5.d4! Exploiting Black's poor move order. 5.d3 leads to Chapter 3 after 4…h6. **5…exd4 6.e5! d5 7.♗b5 ♘e4 8.♘xd4 ♗d7 9.♗xc6** 9.e6!? fxe6 10.♗xc6 bxc6 11.♕h5+ ♔e7 12.♘d2 ♘f6 (Antal-Sandi, Indianapolis 2009) and here 13.♕e2!N improves on White's play, but it's not clear whether White gets enough compensation. **9…bxc6** leads to a theoretically well-known position – usually arising after 3…♘f6 4.d4 – where White has played the useful move 0-0 whereas Black has lost time with …h7-h6 instead of developing his bishop on f8. **10.f3 ♘g5 11.f4 ♘e4 12.♘c3!** Undermining the strong knight on e4. **12…c5** 12…♘xc3 13.bxc3 c5 14.e6!⊡; 12…♗c5 13.♘xe4 dxe4 14.♗e3 0-0 15.♕e2±. **13.♘de2 ♘xc3 14.bxc3!**± White threatens a kingside assault with f4-f5.

D) **3…d6**

analysis diagram

After this modest move White can decide whether to play straight away for an opening advantage by conquering the centre or to transpose to the main line in Chapter 3. **4.c3!** Objectively better than 4.0-0, as it leads to an advantage in all lines. 4.0-0 ♘f6 (4…♗e7 5.a4 ♘f6 6.d3 0-0 7.♖e1 leads to Chapter 3) 5.♖e1 ♗e7 (5…♘xe4?? 6.♖xe4 d5 7.♘xe5!+–) 6.a4!. We found only one game where White played this move in this position. (6.d3 allows 6…♘a5! and White cannot avoid the exchange of his good light-squared bishop) 6…0-0 (6…♘xe4 is a typical idea that doesn't seem to work for Black in this concrete situation: 7.♖xe4 d5 8.♗xd5 ♕xd5 9.♘c3 ♕a5 10.♖b1! 0-0 11.♘xe5! ♘xe5 12.b4 ♗xb4 13.♖bxb4. The white rooks make Black's life hard, for example: 13…♘g6 14.♗a3 ♕a6 15.h4± with an initiative) 7.d3 and we have reached Chapter 3.

analysis diagram

D1) **4…♘f6?! 5.♘g5! d5** 5…♗e6 6.♘xe6! fxe6 7.♕b3!±. **6.exd5 ♘xd5 7.d4** This is a well-known position, usually arising after 3.♗c4 ♘f6 4.♘g5 d5 etc. Here White has an extra tempo as Black has played first …d7-d6 and then …d6-d5. **7…♗e7 8.♘xf7 ♔xf7 9.♕f3+ ♔e6 10.0-0 ♖f8 11.♕e4±** White has a tremendous attack, as several correspondence games confirm;

D2) **4…♗e7 5.♕b3 ♘h6** 5…♘a5? 6.♗xf7+ ♔f8 7.♕a4 ♔xf7 8.♕xa5± is just a pawn up for White. **6.d4 0-0** 6…♘a5? 7.♕a4+ c6 8.♗e2±. **7.♗xh6 gxh6** White has the better structure and enjoys a small plus, e.g.: 8.0-0 ♘a5 9.♕a4 ♘xc4 10.♕xc4 ♗g4 11.♘bd2 ♗g5 12.♖fe1 c5 13.♕d3 ♖c8 14.♘xg5 hxg5 15.♘f1 exd4 16.cxd4 ♕f6 17.♕g3 ♕f4 18.♘e3± Mujunen-Zhuravlev, ICCF email 2014;

D3) 4…♗g4 5.d4 ♗xf3 6.♕xf3 ♕f6 7.♗e3 ♕xf3 8.gxf3±;

D4) **4…h6 5.0-0 ♘f6 6.d4 ♗e7** 6…♘xe4 7.dxe5 ♗e6?! (7…♗e7 8.♖e1 ♗f5 9.♘d4! ♘xd4 10.♕xd4 d5 11.♗xd5 ♘c5 12.♗c4±) 8.♗xe6 fxe6 9.♘d4! ♘xd4 10.♕h5+ ♔d7

11.cxd4± Zelcic-Krnic, Zadar 1994. **7.♖e1 0-0** 7…♗g4 8.♗b5±. **8.h3±**

E) **3…♗e7** As after 3…d6 White can choose between transposing to Chapter 3 or trying to get an advantage with tricky play.

analysis diagram

4.d4 4.0-0 ♘f6 (4…d6 5.a4 ♘f6 6.d3 0-0 7.♖e1 leads to Chapter 3) 5.d3 0-0 6.♖e1 leads to Chapter 3. **4…exd4** On 4…d6, 5.d5 is the engines' favourite as they like to grab space (5.dxe5 dxe5 6.♕xd8+ ♗xd8, 7.♘c3 also offers White good prospects, as in Vasiukov-Gheorghiu, Manila 1974, in our Strategy chapter) 5…♘b8 6.♗d3 ♘f6 7.c4 ♘bd7 8.♘c3 a5 9.h3 ♘c5 10.♗c2 0-0 11.♗e3 b6 12.a3± and White now has a good version of a 'King's Indian' position. **5.c3!?**

analysis diagram

After this move it is very easy for Black to go astray.

E1) 5…d6?! 6.♕b3 ♘a5 7.♗xf7+ ♔f8 8.♕a4 ♔xf7 9.♕xa5 ♘f6 10.cxd4±;

E2) 5…dxc3?! 6.♕d5.

analysis diagram

Many games have, not surprisingly, been resigned at this point, but it is still possible for Black to continue to fight with 6…♘h6 7.♗xh6 0-0 8.♗xg7 ♔xg7 9.♘xc3 d6 10.♕d3±;

E3) 5…d3 6.♕b3 ♘a5 7.♗xf7+ ♔f8 8.♕a4 ♔xf7 9.♕xa5 d5 10.♘e5+ ♔f8 11.♕xd5 ♕xd5 12.exd5±;

E4) 5…♘f6?! 6.e5 ♘e4 7.♗d5!±;

E5) **5…♘a5! 6.♗e2 dxc3** 6…d5 7.♕a4+ c6 8.exd5 ♘f6 9.dxc6 ♘xc6 10.♘xd4±. **7.♘xc3 d6 8.0-0 ♘f6** 8…♘c6 9.♕b3 ♘f6 10.♖d1 ♘d7 11.♗e3 0-0 12.h3 ♕e8 13.♖ac1∞ Ardelean-Pessi, Baile Olanesti 2010. **9.♕a4+ ♘c6 10.e5 dxe5** 10…♘d7 (Andriasyan-Erturan, Dresden Ech 2007) 11.♕g4!N ♔f8 (11…0-0 12.♗h6 g6 13.♗xf8±; 11…♘dxe5 12.♕xg7 ♗f6 13.♕h6±) 12.exd6 ♗xd6 13.♗g5∞. **11.♘xe5 ♗d7** A.Horvath-Pastor Alonso de Prado, Madrid 2012; 11…0-0 12.♖d1 ♗d6 13.♘c4 ♗e6 14.♘xd6 cxd6 15.♕h4 d5 16.♗g5 h6 17.♗xf6 ♕xf6 18.♕xf6 gxf6 19.♘xd5±. **12.♘xd7!N ♕xd7** 12…♘xd7 13.♖d1 0-0 14.♗f4 ♗d6 15.♗xd6 cxd6 16.♖xd6 ♕e7 17.♖ad1±. **13.♖d1 ♕c8** 13…♗d6?! 14.♗g5 0-0 15.♗xf6 gxf6 16.♕h4±. **14.♗f4∞**

4.d4

A good reaction. White immediately attacks the centre as he has a lead in development.

4…exd4 5.c3!

5.♘xd4 ♗g7 6.♘xc6 bxc6 7.0-0 ♘e7 8.♘c3 0-0 9.♗g5 d6 10.♕d2 ♗e6 11.♗b3 ♕d7 12.♖fe1 ♖fe8 (Ganguly-Mamedyarov, Doha 2014) 13.♖ad1N looks a bit better for White, but Black has the nice resource 13…♘c8 with the idea of …♘b6 and pushing the c- and/or a-pawn.

5...d3!

A) **5...♗g7 6.cxd4** This position promises White an edge because of his better control of the centre. **6...d6** Here White can even choose how to gain an advantage. 6...♘ge7 (Lapshun-Guramishvili, Banyoles 2007) 7.d5!N ♘a5 (7...♘b8?! 8.d6!±; 7...♘e5 8.♘xe5 ♗xe5 9.0-0 d6 10.♘c3 0-0 11.♗g5±) 8.♗e2 0-0 9.0-0 d6 10.♘c3±. White has a space advantage and Black needs time to get his knight on a5 back into play.

Now:

A1) **7.♕b3 ♕d7** (Flores-Pina Gomez, Villa Ballester 2004) **8.♗d2!N**

analysis diagram

8...a6 8...♘xd4 9.♘xd4 ♗xd4 10.♗xf7+ ♕xf7 11.♕a4+ ♗d7 12.♕xd4 ♘f6 13.♘c3±. **9.d5 ♘e5 10.♘xe5 ♗xe5 11.0-0 ♕e7 12.♖e1 ♘f6** 12...♗g7?! 13.♗b4 f6 14.f4 ♘h6 15.♘d2 0-0 16.♘f3±. **13.f4 ♗d4+ 14.♗e3 ♗xe3+ 15.♕xe3 0-0 16.♘c3±**;

A2) 7.d5 ♘ce7 (Ptacnikova-Hj.Gretarsson, Reykjavik 2015) 8.0-0!N ♘f6 9.♘c3 0-0 10.♗f4±;

A3) **7.0-0**

A31) **7...♘f6 8.♘c3 0-0 9.h3 ♘xe4** 9...♘a5 10.♗d3 c5 11.dxc5 (11.♗f4!? cxd4 12.♘b5 a6 13.♘xd6 ♗e6 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♗g3±) 11...dxc5 (Hendrickson-Finegold, St Louis 2013) 12.♗g5N h6 13.♗e3±. **10.♘xe4 d5 11.♗g5 f6 12.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 13.♗xf6 ♖xf6** (Krivokapic-Batricevic, Tivat 2011) 14.♗b3!±;

A32) **7...♘ge7 8.♘c3 0-0 9.h3 h6** (9...♘a5 10.♗e2 d5 11.e5±) 10.♖e1± Ramnath-Sidhant, Mumbai 2014.

B) **5...dxc3?!** This dubious move is more or less untested in practice, and rightly so.

B1) **6.♘xc3** and now:

B11) **6...♗g7?! 7.♕b3! ♕e7** 7...♘h6 8.♗xh6 ♗xh6 9.♗xf7+ ♔f8 10.♗d5±.

analysis diagram

8.♘d5! ♕xe4+ 9.♗e2! ♔d8 10.0-0 ♕xe2 10…♘ge7 11.♗g5 h6 12.♘xe7 ♘xe7 13.♗d3 ♕c6 14.♖ac1+–. **11.♗g5+ f6 12.♖fe1+–** and here the computer wants to sacrifice the queen in order to avoid immediate loss;

B12) 6…d6 (Reinert-Hvenekilde, Allerod 1984) 7.0-0!N ♗g7 8.♗g5 ♘ge7 9.♕b3 0-0 10.♘d5 ♔h8 11.♘xe7 ♘xe7 12.♗xf7±.

B2) **6.♕b3!?N** is the computer's favourite: **6…♕e7** 6…♘h6?! 7.0-0! ♗g7 (7…♘a5?? 8.♕xc3+–) 8.♗xh6 ♗xh6 9.♗xf7+ ♔f8 10.♘xc3 ♔g7 11.e5 ♖f8 12.♗d5±. **7.♘xc3 ♘a5** 7…♗g7?! leads to Variation B11: 6.♘xc3 ♗g7 7.♕b3! ♕e7; see diagram above. **8.♕b5 ♘xc4 9.♕xc4 c6 10.0-0 d6 11.♗f4 ♗g4 12.♖ad1 ♗xf3 13.gxf3 ♖d8 14.♕d4 f6 15.♕xa7 ±**

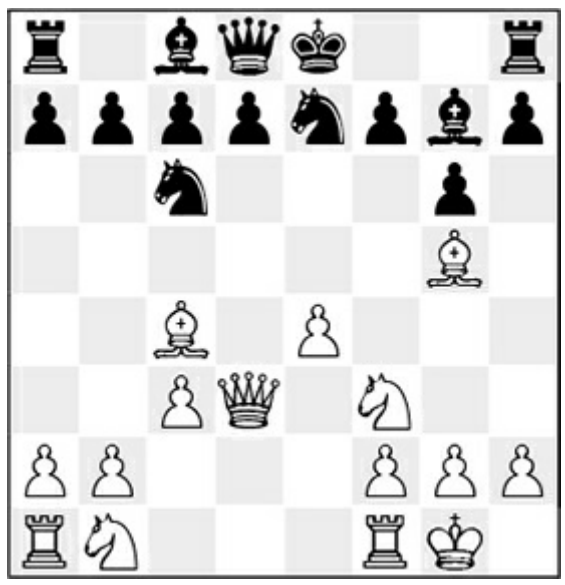
6.0-0

Other moves are equally good and promise White a small edge as well.

A) 6.♗g5!? (disturbing Black's harmony) 6…♗e7 (Pokorna-Matnadze, Germany Bundesliga W 2012/13) 7.♗f4!N ♘f6 8.♕xd3 0-0 9.0-0 d6 10.♘bd2±;

B) 6.♕xd3 ♗g7 7.0-0 ♘ge7 8.♗f4 d6 9.♘bd2 0-0 10.♖ad1 h6 11.♖fe1 g5 12.♗g3 ♘g6 (Pourkashiyan-Melia, Halkidiki jr 2003) 13.h3!±.

6…♗g7 7.♗g5 ♘ge7 8.♕xd3



8…d6

8…h6 9.♗e3 d6 10.♕d2 (10.♘bd2 leads to the text) 10…♗e6 11.♗xe6 fxe6 12.♘a3 ♕d7 13.♘c2 g5= Schippers-Semcesen, Vlissingen 2014.

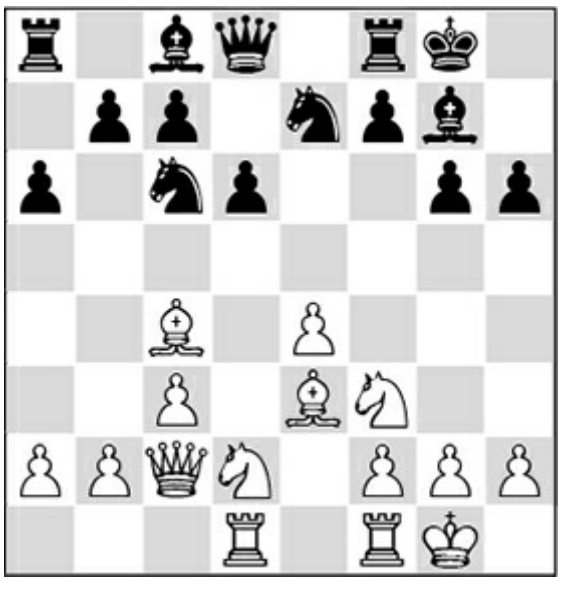
9.♘bd2!N

9.♕e3 h6! 10.♗h4 (Jayakumaar-Rajdeep, Jammu jr 2015) 10…0-0=.

9…h6

9…0-0 10.♕e3!±.

10.♗e3 0-0 11.♖ad1 a6 12.♕c2



White enjoys a small plus due to his better development, better piece placement and small space advantage.

Conclusion

In this chapter we have focussed on rare moves after 3.♗c4. After 3…f5?!, 3…♘d4?! and 3…h6?! White has the upper hand. After 3…d6 and 3…♗e7 White can transpose to Chapter 3 or try to get an immediate advantage. 3…g6 has to be considered seriously. White gets a small advantage by opening up the centre and developing his pieces naturally in the centre. Black has quite a solid position, but he has weakened his kingside a little and has problems finishing his development without further weakening the position.